

SERMON · TRUE WORSHIP

# NEAR WITH THE LIPS, FAR WITH THE HEART

*Recovering Authentic Worship in an Age of Religious Performance*

## ISAIAH 29:13

*Wherefore the Lord said, Forasmuch as this people draw near me with their mouth, and with their lips do honour me, but have removed their heart far from me, and their fear toward me is taught by the precept of men.*

## INTRODUCTION

It is possible to sing every song, raise both hands, quote every verse, and still stand at a distance from God. That is the uncomfortable truth Isaiah confronted in his generation, and it is the same truth Jesus picked up seven centuries later and aimed directly at the most religiously disciplined people of His day — the Pharisees. Authentic worship was never primarily a matter of posture, vocabulary, or attendance. It is a matter of the heart. This morning we ask a question none of us can afford to avoid: is my worship near to God, or only near in appearance?

### PREACHER'S NOTE

*Open gently — this text can easily be heard as an accusation rather than an invitation to self-examination. Frame it early as a mirror for personal reflection, not a weapon aimed at anyone else in the room.*

## I. Worship Can Be Near in Word and Far in Heart

Isaiah's indictment is precise: the people drew near with their mouth and honoured God with their lips. This was not irreligious Israel — this was a nation still going through the motions of covenant worship, still speaking the right words. The failure was internal: the heart had been removed, quietly and gradually, from the very words the mouth kept speaking.

## MATTHEW 15:7–9

*Ye hypocrites, well did Esaias prophesy of you, saying, This people draweth nigh unto me with their mouth, and honoureth me with their lips; but their heart is far from me. But in vain they do worship me, teaching for doctrines the commandments of men.*

Jesus quotes Isaiah word for word and applies it to the Pharisees — men who fasted, tithed, and studied Scripture with extraordinary discipline. If outward religious performance alone were the test, they would have passed with distinction. Jesus calls their worship vain — literally, empty, without substance — because the heart driving it had drifted from God while the mouth kept performing devotion.

### Application for today

- Regular attendance, fluent prayer language, and confident Bible knowledge can all coexist with a heart that has quietly drifted.
- Ask: Has my worship become fluent performance rather than genuine encounter?

### PREACHER'S NOTE

*Illustrate carefully and without naming individuals: a worship leader who can lead a congregation into song while personally feeling nothing, or a long-time member whose prayers have become habitual recitation. Let the congregation supply their own example rather than pointing at anyone specific.*

## II. The Danger of Worship Shaped by Human Precept

Isaiah adds a second diagnosis: their fear toward God was taught by the precept of men. In other words, their religion had become inherited habit and social expectation rather than living relationship — rules and customs passed down until the form remained but the encounter that first produced the form was long forgotten.

### JOHN 4:23–24

*But the hour cometh, and now is, when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth: for the Father seeketh such to worship him. God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.*

Jesus tells the Samaritan woman that the Father is not primarily looking for the correct location, ritual, or tradition of worship — He is seeking worshippers whose spirit genuinely engages Him, grounded in truth rather than mere custom. This does not dismiss form or reverence; it insists that form without living relationship is not what God is seeking.

#### Application for today

- Examine which of your spiritual habits are alive with genuine devotion, and which have become inherited routine you no longer question.
- Ask: Am I worshipping the way I was taught because it is truly mine, or only because it is familiar?

## III. The Heart God Actually Receives

If Isaiah and Jesus diagnose the counterfeit, David shows us the real thing. David was no stranger to failure, yet after his greatest sin he did not offer God elaborate ritual — he offered God what these other worshippers had removed.

### PSALM 51:16–17

*For thou desirest not sacrifice; else would I give it: thou delightest not in burnt offering. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit: a broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not despise.*

David understood something the outwardly religious often miss: God is not impressed by the volume or correctness of our ritual. He responds to honesty — a heart that comes broken and truthful rather than polished and performative. Authentic worship does not require us to have everything resolved before we approach God; it requires us to stop pretending in His presence.

#### Application for today

- Bring God your actual condition, not the version of yourself you present to the congregation.
- Ask: When did I last worship with complete honesty rather than composed performance?

#### PREACHER'S NOTE

*This is a strong moment for a prayer response — consider pausing here for a moment of silent, honest confession before continuing to the closing section, rather than saving all response for the very end.*

## SYNTHESIS: THE DISTANCE ONLY GOD CAN SEE

Outward religion can fool a congregation, a family, even the worshipper himself. It cannot fool God. Isaiah's word and Jesus' repetition of it centuries later both establish the same unchanging standard: the mouth can honour God while the

heart has quietly walked away, and only an honest return of the heart — not louder lips or more disciplined ritual — closes that distance. The invitation this morning is not to worship harder, but to worship truer.

## PERSONAL REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

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1. Which of my regular spiritual practices still involve real engagement with God, and which have become routine?
2. Is there an area of my life where my words about God and my heart toward God have quietly separated?
3. What would it look like for me to bring God my honest, unpolished condition this week rather than a composed version of myself?
4. Whose voice has shaped my worship more — God's Word, or inherited human tradition I have never examined?

## CLOSING PRAYER

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Father, search us and know our hearts today. Forgive us for the times our lips have honoured You while our hearts drifted elsewhere, and for worship that became performance instead of encounter. Create in us a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within us. We do not bring You polished ritual this morning — we bring You ourselves, honestly, and ask that our worship would once again be near to You in truth, not only in word. In Jesus' name, Amen.

### PREACHER'S NOTE

*Consider closing with an extended altar call rather than a quick transition — this message often surfaces things people have not admitted even to themselves. Give unhurried space for response.*